Preserving family heirlooms

Andrew Potocnik completes another turner's work to preserve a pedestal table

ANDREW POTOCNIK

Andrew sees inspiration around him every day. He 'arrived' on the Australian woodworking scene in 1983, and since then, his work has developed into areas of sculpture, furniture making and the odd bit of cabinetwork.

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PHOTOGRAPHS BY ANDREW POTOCNIK

A friend recently called in with a box of items his late father made while in retirement when he developed an interest in woodworking and became intrigued with the combination of turning and furniture making. Unfortunately after he passed away he left behind several partially completed projects, hence my challenge was to complete some of them, which will eventually be passed on to grandchildren as heirlooms with which they can remember their grandfather. My task was to finish off components of a small pedestal table that combined turning and cabinet skills.

This job presented me with a rather delicate juggling act. I needed to work with a design aesthetic outside my own, yet I felt components needed to be 'tweaked' to make them blend and form a table that was balanced once completed, without overpowering the original maker's personal style. I first needed approval from my friend to alter the design but not override his father's touch, after which I was off and ready to work, but constantly aware of not overstepping my limits and imposing personal tastes on those of the deceased and the heirloom significance of his work.

As you can imagine, the most difficult aspect of reworking an almost completed item lies in how to mount it for further modification. Lateral thinking comes in handy here, as does a bit of experience, so I began with the top and worked my way down to the three feet… gently.

The original feet

The original stem

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